the quiet library

there was once a library where every book was written by someone.

you could ask any book, "who wrote you, and how do you know?" and it would tell you.

it was quiet. and true.

a magic press

one night, a printing press arrived that could write a whole book in a second.

it learned how to write by reading every book on the shelves.

by morning, there were ten thousand new books. some of them were wonderful!

more! more!

the shelves overflowed, so the town built new wings. then new floors. then a basement under the basement.

the press wrote books about books, summaries of summaries, and a cookbook full of soups nobody had ever tasted.

a copy of a copy

then the press ran out of people's books to read. so it read its own.

each copy blurred a little. in the first book, a hand waved hello with five fingers. by the tenth copy, it had eleven.

nobody noticed.

cut along the dashes

lost in the stacks

a girl came looking for her grandmother's bread recipe.

she found four thousand bread recipes. none of them had ever been baked.

more pages. less library.

the librarians' fix

the librarians held a meeting, very quietly, and made some rules:

- stamp every book: made by hand, or made by the press
- keep the originals safe in the cellar
- make the press say where it learned things
- bake the bread before you print the recipe

the moral

the press isn't the problem. forgetting where words came from is.

a machine that writes is a fine tool. a library that can't tell you what's true is a maze.

> when you read something, ask: who made this, and how do they know?

(the recipe was in the cellar all along.)

the

LIBRARY

that wrote itself

a tale told again, and again, and again